Bar Owner Steals the Show in Subway Improv With Conan O'Brien

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It is not every day that running **errands** turns into an **improv** show with a famous comedian on the New York City subway. But that is exactly what happened to Debbie Shields, a Brooklyn bar owner who runs a comedy night.

Shields was on her way to see her **accountant** for her business when she struck up a conversation with comedian Conan O'Brien. She had no idea what she was walking into and she was more than ready. 'If you give it to me, I give it right back to you,' she later said.

O'Brien was a guest on SubwayTakes, a popular internet talk show hosted by comedian Kareem Rahma, where everyday New Yorkers and celebrities humorously discuss their controversial opinions while riding the subway. Toward the end of O'Brien's episode, he apologized to Shields as she moved into an empty seat next to Rahma. The two shook hands and jumped into a **spontaneous** scene together, with O'Brien joking that they used to be married.

Shields fired back instantly: they had two kids. 'One's in medical school, the other one's in jail,' she said and the former late-night host cracked up. Viewers said they loved her wit and her ability to keep up with O'Brien. He was impressed, too. O'Brien told New York Magazine he would love to work with Shields again. 'I'll do a sitcom with her,' he said. 'Or we can just hit the road, do a two-person show.'

Shields said she would love to **collaborate** again. Since the episode aired, she has become an internet **sensation**, with calls coming in from around the world Japan at 1:30 in the morning, Australia, England. 'It's crazy right now,' she said. 'Oh boy, it's been busy.'

Not bad for a trip to the **accountant**.

Word Treasure

improv -- Comedy made up on the spot, without a script.
errands -- Small jobs or trips, like going to a shop or an office.
accountant -- A person who keeps track of money for a business.
spontaneous -- Happening suddenly, without planning.
sensation -- Someone or something that suddenly becomes very popular.
collaborate -- To work together on something.

Background you need

Improv is comedy made up on the spot, without a script, so performers must react quickly to whatever their partner says.

SubwayTakes is an internet talk show recorded while riding the New York City subway, where everyday New Yorkers and celebrities discuss their strong opinions.

A bar owner who runs a comedy night already spends time around jokes and performers, which helps explain why Shields could keep up with a famous comedian.

When a clip spreads widely online, the person in it can suddenly receive attention from around the world.

Break it down

LEAD: A trip to run errands turned into an improv show with Conan O'Brien on the New York City subway.

KEY EVENT: Brooklyn bar owner Debbie Shields improvised a scene with O'Brien on SubwayTakes.

+- WHO: Debbie Shields, Conan O'Brien and host Kareem Rahma.
+- WHERE: On the subway, on her way to see her accountant.
+- WHAT: A spontaneous scene in which O'Brien joked they used to be married.
+- HOW: Shields fired back instantly about their two kids, and O'Brien cracked up.

EVIDENCE: Viewers loved her wit; O'Brien told New York Magazine he would love to work with her again.

OPEN QUESTION: Whether the two will collaborate again, as both said they would love to.

Why it matters

It shows how an unplanned moment can reach people around the world once it is shared online. It also shows that being ready to join in can open doors, since O'Brien now wants to work with Shields again.

Test what you remember

1. Where did Shields meet Conan O'Brien?

(A) At her bar
(B) On the New York City subway
(C) At a TV studio
(D) In a medical school

2. Why was Shields on the subway?

(A) On her way to see her accountant
(B) To host her comedy night
(C) To interview O'Brien
(D) To visit Japan

3. What show was O'Brien a guest on?

(A) A sports show
(B) SubwayTakes
(C) A news show
(D) A cooking show

4. What did Shields say about their two kids?

(A) Both work at her bar
(B) Both are comedians
(C) One is an accountant
(D) One's in medical school, the other one's in jail

5. What did O'Brien say he would love to do?

(A) Open a bar with her
(B) Work with Shields again, in a sitcom or a two-person show
(C) Move to Japan
(D) Host her comedy night

6. Since the episode aired, what has happened to Shields?

(A) She closed her bar
(B) She stopped doing comedy
(C) She moved to Australia
(D) She has become an internet sensation with calls from around the world

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: B 6: D

Questions to think about

1. **Viewers: They loved her wit and her ability to keep up with O'Brien.**
2. **Conan O'Brien: He would love to work with Shields again.**
3. **Debbie Shields: She would love to collaborate again.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):